

Chapter 11

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- The most salient features of Southern English to non-southern listeners
- Non-southern perceptions of the Deep South and its dialects
- The ways that Southerners perceive themselves and their speech
- A discussion of the differences between covert and overt prestige
- The linguistic diversity of the South
- Bourdieu's strategies of condescension and the linguistic subordination of Southern English
- The way people connect language variety, communication, and intelligence in regards to Southern English
- The stereotypes that Northern intelligence to education and Southern intelligence to common sense
- The issue of accent reduction, especially for speakers of Southern English

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. *In this chapter, the popular entertainment examples that contribute to southern stereotypes are dated. You may not know who Lil' Abner is, and you may never have seen an episode of The Beverly Hillbillies. Does this indicate to you a decline in southern stereotypes? If not, where are the current day stereotypes to be found? How were your beliefs and opinions about the South (or the North) formed? If you are interested in pursuing this question, you may want to start with Cooke-Jackson and Hansen (2008) "Appalachian Culture and Reality TV: The Ethical Dilemma of Stereotyping Others."*

Sample answer: I don't think this necessarily indicates the decline of southern stereotypes. There are still southern stereotypes in shows; for example, the unintelligent Southern couple in *The Simpsons*. I must have formed my opinions about the South from the media because one side of my family is Southern (now living in California), and I don't remember anyone in my family vocalizing a distaste for Southern accents. However, somehow I acquired a language ideology that devalues Southern English, and I remember disliking Southern accents growing up.

2. *Read the following article:*

Knight, D. (2000) Standards. In Standard Speech and Other Contemporary Issues in Professional Voice and Speech Training. R. Dal Vera (ed.) New York: Applause 61-78.

Summarize Knight's main points and his arguments. Which ones do you find credible, and why?

Sample answer: Knight's main arguments are: there is no one "best" accent and no accent is

superior to another, accent discrimination does happen, but the arguments in *English with an Accent* are flawed, and the practice of accent reduction is not a part of a hegemonic language regime. I think some of Knight's points are very credible; for example, I applaud his assertions that all language varieties are equally valid media of expression, and I do agree with him that there are surely some English speakers who seek out accent reduction specialists because their pronunciations truly do provide a communication barrier despite the best efforts of the speaker and the listener. However, I disagree with his dismissals of several of arguments in this book. For example, he argues that Bill Clinton's southern accent constitutes proof that accent bias against southerners is not as big a problem as Lippi-Green makes it out to be. I do not find this argument of his to be very compelling – just because there are some very successful southerners does not mean that less successful southerners do not face serious discrimination in the workplace.

3. If you are a Southerner, how many different southern accents do you recognize? Do you consider yourself good at telling accents apart? What features do you take note of when people talk? Which accents do you dislike, and can you figure out why, objectively?

Sample answer: Answers will vary.

4. If you know a child of ten years or so and have that child's parent's permission, see if you can elicit opinions about the South (or North, depending on where you live) without leading. If this isn't possible, try someone of your grandparent's generation. Compare your findings in class.

Sample answer: I interviewed my 9-year-old niece and asked her some questions about the South. I found out that even at 9 years old, my niece already has firmly entrenched negative stereotypes about the South and Southern accents. For example, she seems to think that the South is filled with poor, uneducated people and rich, charming people with nobody in between. She dislikes Southern English although she was unable to articulate why she doesn't like it.

5. Without thinking or preparation, write down as many non-fictional Southerners you can think of. These can be personal acquaintances or public figures. When you're finished, go back and try to be specific about what part of the South each person comes from. Check your answers for accuracy. What results do you draw from this exercise? (If you are a Southerner, reverse this process and make a list of Northerners or Westerners). If you are a Southerner, how much do you know about (for example) North Dakota as compared to Michigan, or Kansas compared to Idaho? Do you notice any linguistic differentiation? Is there differentiation that you just don't hear?

Sample answer: I was not able to determine the home states of the people on my list whose background I didn't already know. For example, I guessed that Matthew McConaughey was from Alabama, but he is actually from Texas. I realize from this exercise that I am unable to match a Southern dialect with a place, despite the fact that I can hear the variation between dialects.

6. Read the entire column by Withrow quoted at the beginning of the section called "Hostility with a Southern Accent." Consider that you have been engaged by the same newspaper to write a

column that represents a different point of view. What ways might it be possible to approach Withrow to have a calm and rational discussion about the subject of grammar? She clearly feels very strongly about this subject, and she will need to be approached carefully, with solid arguments.

Sample answer: I would start by describing grammatical differences between *SAE and British RP to give examples of grammatical differences between two highly valued language varieties. Then, I would explain the rules that govern the parts of the grammar that offend her so she could see that it is indeed rule-governed, and I would include some examples from other dialects (or other languages even) that do things in a similar way. Finally, I would discuss the linguist's perspective that all human dialects and languages are equally systematic, rule-governed, and expressive. I would weave in some details about prescriptivism, standard language ideology, and language subordination in an attempt to inform her of these issues without accusing her and putting her on the defensive so she may be more open to discussion.

7. A woman writes to Dear Abby to say that she has moved to the Boston area after living her whole life in Jackson, Mississippi. It has been two years, but she is still not used to people laughing in her face and mocking her accent. She doesn't understand why people find this not only acceptable, but amusing. She wants to know how best to respond when she comes across this behavior. How do you think Miss Abby will respond, and why?

Sample answer: I suspect that Miss Abby would respond by suggesting that the woman takes accent reduction classes. I think most people would expect people who speak devalued language varieties to want to change the way they speak and would find it acceptable for speakers of more valued language varieties to find devalued accents amusing or distasteful.

8. In an article called "Nationalization of a Southernism," Tillery et al. (2000) present evidence that one feature of southern U.S. English is actually spreading into the north, at a good pace. What feature do you think this might be? Read the article and discuss how and why this might be happening. If you would like to look at this issue more closely, read Hyman (2006).

Sample answer: I suspected that the Southern feature spreading from the South to the rest of the country might be *y'all*. I think this feature would be very transmittable to other areas because *SAE does not have a firmly established second person plural pronoun (although there are other regional ways of handling this).

From the website

Audio

1. Listen to the clips of Southern English. Can you hear the variation? Can you tell which region of the South these dialects are from? Are some dialects more strongly devalued than others? Which ones do you think would be most accepted by outsiders? Why do you think that is?

Sample answer: I can definitely hear the variation in the Southern accents provided here, but I wouldn't be able to tell which accent came from which location. I think that the accents that have

more subtle features of Southern English, such as Virginia 1 or Tennessee 9, would be more accepted by outsiders, whereas accents with more obvious features of Southern English would be more devalued. Also, I don't know what features this would be based on, but I would think that varieties that are associated with the upper class would be more valued than varieties that are associated with the working class.

Video

John Reep—"Southerners"

Comedy Central Stand-Up

<http://comedians.jokes.com/jon-reep/videos/jon-reep---southerners>

Gary Valentine—"Southern Accents"

Comedy Central Stand-Up

<http://comedians.jokes.com/gary-valentine/videos/gary-valentine---southern-accents>

1. Analyze these two clips in light of what you have learned in Chapter 11. How is Southern English represented in these clips? What stereotypes of people who speak Southern English are apparent? Why does Gary Valentine imitate Southern English in his routine, and what does his use of Southern English reveal about his language ideology?

Sample answer: In the first clip, a native speaker of Southern English depicts the dialect as one associated with the country by emphasizing that he is not from the city – any city. He also makes light of stereotypes of southern small towns as being filled with “rednecks,” “hillbillies,” and “hicks” in his routine, clarifying at the end that he encounters these stereotypes now as a resident of Los Angeles. He makes it clear that the stereotype he encounters in LA is one that expects speakers of Southern English to be so ridiculously stupid and/or unsophisticated as to not know what shoes are for.

In the second clip, the comedian uses the subordinated dialect of Southern English for a short time in order to mock it. This is what Bourdieu called a strategy of condescension. The comedian's mocking use of Southern English and comparison of some dialects of the South to the sounds of his dry heaving clearly show that, at least for the purposes of this routine, he strongly devalues many southern varieties of English. The audience is complicit in this devaluing of Southern English through its laughter and applause, explicitly supporting the mockery of “thick” Southern accents. In addition, this comedian also draws upon the stereotypes of Southern women being cute, sexy, charming, and hospitable.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Revisit Bourdieu's idea of strategies of condescension and then ask your students if they have ever heard someone imitate Southern English in order to mock it. What was the context? What was the message the person was sending to his or her addressees? What does that non-Southerner's use of Southern English reveal about his or her language ideology?

2. Discuss the notions of overt and covert prestige. Do the students attach covert prestige to a certain way of speaking? If so, ask them to provide details on what the covertly prestigious language variety is like and with whom they gain prestige by speaking it.
3. Ask your students why they think Southern English is devalued while Western and Midwestern English are more highly valued. What could be behind this language ideology?
4. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.